

JAPAN 2025

The Ultimate Trip Guide

Jul 27 - Aug 4, 2025

Tokyo . Hakone . Kyoto . Osaka

3 Travelers . 9 Days

CITY	DATES	NIGHTS
Tokyo	Jul 27-29	2
Hakone	Jul 30	1
Kyoto	Jul 31	1
Osaka	Aug 1-2	2
Tokyo	Aug 3	1

■ DAY-BY-DAY ITINERARY

Jul 27 (Sun) — ARRIVE TOKYO

4:00 PM

Land at Narita International Airport

5:00 PM

Narita Express (N'EX) → Tokyo Station (~60 min, ~¥3,000)

■ Buy Suica IC card at the airport station machine before boarding

6:00 PM

Check in — Imperial Hotel Tokyo

7:00 PM

Dinner nearby — grab ramen or izakaya, nothing fancy

■ Sleep early. You're 13 hours ahead of NYC

Jul 28 (Mon) — TOKYO — FISH MARKET + TEMPLE + NIGHTLIFE

5:30 AM

Toyosu Market — Tuna auction viewing gallery + fresh sushi breakfast

■ BOOK IN ADVANCE via lottery at toyosu-market.or.jp. Yurikamome Line from Shimbashi

9:30 AM

Senso-ji Temple, Asakusa — Tokyo's most iconic Buddhist temple

■ Walk Nakamise Street for snacks and souvenirs. Subway Asakusa Line

11:30 AM

Pokemon Center Skytree Town — 10-min walk from Senso-ji

■ Exclusive Skytree Pikachu plush. Open 10am-9pm

1:00 PM

Ameyoko Market, Ueno — outdoor bargain market

■ Clothes, cosmetics, seafood stalls, street food. Short train from Skytree

8:00 PM

Shinjuku Golden-Gai — 200+ tiny bars in labyrinth alleyways

■ Bar-hop 3-4 spots, each fits ~6 people. Best after 8pm. Take train to Shinjuku

Jul 29 (Tue) — TOKYO — LOCAL LIFE + CHECKOUT + NIGHT TRAIN

9:30 AM

Tokyo National Museum, Ueno — Japan's greatest museum

■ Samurai armor, Buddhist sculpture, ceramics, silk screens. Budget 2hrs. Open Tue-Sun

12:00 PM

Yanaka Ginza — 5-min walk from museum

■ Old Tokyo at its best. Narrow lanes, cat shops, local food stalls, zero tourists

2:00 PM

Shimokitazawa — Tokyo's coolest local neighborhood

■ Vintage clothes, indie records, quirky cafes. Where young Tokyo actually hangs out

3:30 PM

Takeshita Street, Harajuku — Wild J-fashion, crepes, street food

5:00 PM

DINNER — Gyukatsu Motomura, Shibuya (4.9 stars)

■ Rare beef cutlet you grill on a hot stone. Queue 30-60min, worth every second. ~\$25pp

6:30 PM

Shibuya Crossing — walk it, feel the chaos

■ Best at evening rush hour. Starbucks above has great aerial view

7:30 PM

Pokemon Center Mega Tokyo, Ikebukuro — biggest in Japan

■ Full floor + Pikachu cafe. 10 min by Yamanote Line. Pick up hotel bags on the way

9:00 PM

Omoide Yokocho 'Memory Lane', Shinjuku — smoky yakitori alley

■ Tiny lantern-lit stalls, grilled skewers, cold beer. Perfect Tokyo farewell

10:30 PM

Romancecar from Shinjuku → Hakone-Yumoto (~85 min)

■ BOOK IN ADVANCE at odakyu.jp/english. Assigned seating

■ DAY-BY-DAY ITINERARY (continued)

Jul 30 (Wed) — HAKONE — OPEN-AIR MUSEUM + MT. FUJI ONSEN

11:00 AM

Hakone Open-Air Museum — Japan's best open-air sculpture museum

■ Picasso pavilion, stained-glass tower, natural foot onsen on site. Hakone Tozan train from Hakone-Yumoto

3:00 PM

Check in — Fuji Kawaguchiko Onsen Hotel Konansou

■ Private onsen with Mt. Fuji view, rooftop foot bath. BOOK PRIVATE ONSEN SLOT in advance

7:00 PM

Kaiseki multi-course dinner — included in ryokan room rate

■ Note: Toyosu Market is closed Wednesdays — perfect timing to be out of Tokyo

Jul 31 (Thu) — TRAVEL TO KYOTO + MUSEUM + FUSHIMI INARI

Morning

Checkout → bus to Odawara → Shinkansen to Kyoto (~2.5 hrs)

■ JR Pass covers this. Hotel Granvia is directly inside Kyoto Station

2:00 PM

Check in — Hotel Granvia Kyoto

2:30 PM

Kyoto National Museum — samurai armor, Buddhist sculpture, ink paintings

■ 15-min bus/walk from station. Closed Mondays. Open until 8pm on Fridays

5:30 PM

Fushimi Inari Taisha — thousands of vermillion torii gates

■ JR Nara Line from Kyoto Station (10 min). Go at dusk — golden light, fewer crowds. Free, open 24hrs

Aug 1 (Fri) — KYOTO → OSAKA — BAMBOO + MARKETS + GION + CASTLE + AQUARIUM

7:00 AM

Arashiyama Bamboo Forest — arrive before 8am for an empty grove

■ JR Sagano Line from Kyoto Station (25 min). Walk to Tenryu-ji temple garden nearby. Free

11:00 AM

Nishiki Market — Kyoto's covered food street

■ Graze on pickles, grilled skewers, fresh tofu, matcha sweets, uni. Perfect lunch

1:30 PM

Hanamikoji Street, Gion — traditional wooden teahouses, geiko district

■ Walk slowly, take photos. Dinner at Pontocho alley — riverside open-air restaurants

Evening

Shinkansen Kyoto → Osaka (15 min). Check into Osaka Airbnb

Aug 1 (Sat) continued — OSAKA — POKEMON + CASTLE + AQUARIUM + NIGHTLIFE

10:00 AM

Pokemon Center Osaka — Daimaru Umeda dept store, 13th floor

■ One of Japan's biggest Pokemon Centers. Opens 10am

11:00 AM

Osaka Castle — iconic 16th-century castle

■ Grounds are free, museum costs extra (~\$10). Panoramic city views from top. 20-min subway from Umeda

2:30 PM

Osaka Aquarium Kaiyukan — two massive whale sharks

■ BUY TICKETS ONLINE at kaiyukan.com. Budget 2-3hrs. 20-min subway from castle

5:30 PM

Kuromon Market — Osaka's 'kitchen'

■ Fresh seafood, wagyu skewers, uni, tuna. CLOSES AT 6PM — go before stalls shut!

8:00 PM

Dotonbori — neon canal district

■ Takoyaki, ramen, crab restaurants, buzzing bars. Walk the canal, eat everything

■ DAY-BY-DAY ITINERARY (continued)

Aug 2 (Sat) — UNIVERSAL STUDIOS JAPAN — FULL DAY

8:00 AM

Universal Studios Japan — full day!

■ JR Sakurajima Line from Osaka Station (15 min). BOOK TICKETS + EXPRESS PASS NOW at usj.co.jp

On arrival

Open USJ app → reserve Super Nintendo World timed entry immediately

■ Also reserve Harry Potter World if possible. Without Express Pass, queues are 60-220 min

6:30 PM

Namba Parks — rooftop garden mall

■ Last chance for clothes, souvenirs, fashion. Shops close 9pm, restaurants 11pm

Evening

Final Dotonbori dinner or sit-down kaiseki

Aug 3 (Sun) — RETURN TO TOKYO

Morning

Leisure morning in Osaka — last coffee, last takoyaki

Afternoon

Shinkansen Osaka → Tokyo (~2.5 hrs)

■ JR Pass covers this. Book a hotel near Tokyo Station for the early airport run

Evening

Chill in Tokyo — early night, set multiple alarms

Aug 4 (Mon) — DEPART NARITA — 8:00 AM FLIGHT

5:00 AM

N'EX from Tokyo Station → Narita Airport (~60 min)

■ Catch the 5:00-5:15am train. Arrives Narita ~6:20am

6:00 AM

Be at your gate — check in, security, immigration

■ International departures at Narita can be slow. Do not cut this close

8:00 AM

✈ ■ Wheels up — Newark bound

■ COMPLETE BOOKING CHECKLIST

BOOK IMMEDIATELY — TIME SENSITIVE

#	WHAT	WHERE / HOW	WHEN NEEDED
1	Toyosu Tuna Auction Lottery (apply ~2 months ahead)	toyosu-market.or.jp	Jul 28
2	USJ Entry Tickets + Express Pass (August peak — sells out fast)	usj.co.jp	Aug 2
3	JR Pass 7-Day (3 passes) Buy BEFORE leaving the US	jrpass.com or japanrailpass.net	Activate Jul 28
4	Konansou Ryokan + Private Onsen slot Limited rooms, book early	konansou.com	Jul 30

BOOK A FEW WEEKS AHEAD

#	WHAT	WHERE / HOW	WHEN NEEDED
5	Osaka Aquarium Kaiyukan tickets Skip the queue, especially on a Saturday	kaiyukan.com	Aug 1 (Sat)
6	Hakone Open-Air Museum Discounted online, no queue	hakone-oam.or.jp	Jul 30
7	Romancecar — Shinjuku → Hakone-Yumoto ~10:30pm on Jul 29. Assigned seating	odakyu.jp/english	Jul 29 night
8	Kyoto Airbnb (1 night) Near Kyoto Station for easy transport	airbnb.com	Jul 31
9	Osaka Airbnb (2 nights) Near Namba — central for everything	airbnb.com	Aug 1-2
10	Tokyo Airbnb near Tokyo Station (1 night) Critical — you need the 5am N'EX	airbnb.com	Aug 3

ON ARRIVAL — DAY OF

#	WHAT	DETAILS
11	Suica IC Card	Get at Narita Airport station machine. Load 10,000 yen each (x3). Tap on/off every train, subway and bus.
12	USJ App — Super Nintendo World entry	Reserve your timed entry slot the moment you walk through the USJ gates on Aug 2. Also grab Harry Potter

■ BUDGET BREAKDOWN — 3 PEOPLE (excl. flights)

CATEGORY	LOW EST.	HIGH EST.	NOTES
Accommodation (excl. Imperial Tokyo)	\$920	\$1,450	Ryokan Hakone + 3 Airbnbs
Transportation	\$825	\$825	JR Pass x3, N'EX, Romancecar, Suica
Attractions	\$795	\$1,000	Museums, USJ, Aquarium, Hakone museum
Food & Drink (\$70/person/day x 9 days)	\$1,890	\$1,890	Markets, ramen, izakayas, bars included
Shopping	\$900	\$1,800	Pokemon, clothes, souvenirs — be honest!
TOTAL (group)	\$5,330	\$6,965	
PER PERSON	~\$1,775	~\$2,320	Budget \$2,000-2,500 for breathing room

■ ESSENTIAL TRAVEL TIPS

Transit	Use Google Maps on transit mode — it's incredibly accurate in Japan. Always check last train times. Trains in Japan run exactly on time.
Cash	Japan is still heavily cash-based. Withdraw yen from 7-Eleven or Japan Post ATMs (accept foreign cards). Keep ¥10,000-20,000 on you at all times.
Luggage	Use Takuhaibin (luggage forwarding) between cities — drop bags at your hotel, they arrive at next hotel same day for ~\$10/bag. Ask hotel front desk.
Etiquette	No eating while walking (except at markets). Quiet on trains. No phone calls on trains. Bow slightly when thanking people. Trash cans are almost non-existent — carry a small bag.
Language	Download Google Translate with Japanese offline pack. Snap photos of menus for instant translation. Most transit signs are in English.
Pokemon Centers	Items sell out fast — go early in the day. The Mega Tokyo (Ikebukuro) has the best selection. Bring extra yen — you will spend more than planned.
USJ Pro Tips	Arrive 30 min before gates open. Go to Super Nintendo World first thing via app reservation. Express Pass is mandatory in August — queues hit 3+ hours otherwise.
Hakone	Get the Hakone Freepass at Shinjuku Odakyu station — covers all local Hakone transport including ropeways, buses, and lake ferries. Worth it even for 1 night.